First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 6
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Reawakening to What Our Souls Already Know
11 October 2026

COMMUNION

Preaching: ML
Worship Leading: Emily Kang, Gavin Gregorio, and LVF
Tech needs: one solo microphone

Organ Prelude-Concert

CB: Some of the selections below are re-programmed from last week because I ran out of time.

Improvisation on SLANE and OLD HUNDREDTH

ST. DENIO (William H. Bates) and Improvisation

Pastorale (Cécile Chaminade)

VATER UNSER IM HIMMELREICH (Samuel Scheidt)

Meditation on LACQUIPARLE

Vorspiel in D Major (Johann Christian Heinrich Rinck) and Improvisation

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Laura, Emily, and Gavin to center chancel]

Welcome **LVF**

Words of Gathering **LVF, Emily, and Gavin**
Emily: Fountain of life…
Gavin: Pulse of life…
Laura: Breath of life…
All: ***Earth is filled with the presentness of God.***

Emily: A planet filled with the presence of God
a living green blue planet,
people from every corner of creation,
the vast reaches of space above us,

and the rocks and hills and wonders of the wild.

Gavin: Together this day,
let us sense and feel
the face of God in all creation.

All: ***Together this day,***
let us celebrate the life-giving
breath of our God.

Laura: ***Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering***

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Hymn Of Gathering** ***Creator God You Gave Us Life **OLD HUNDREDTH**

Creator God, you gave us life,
Your image formed within our souls,
Yet through the mist of time and space,
We search for that which makes us whole.

In every flow'r and every tree,
We see your great diversity,
Yet greater still we see your love,
Expressed in our humanity.

When with our hearts, our hands our minds,
We share our gifts with all the world,
Our spirits sour beyond the veil,
To touch the very face of God.

Through hands that paint majestic skies,
And voices chanting melody,
With words that reach beyond the page,
We comprehend your mystery.

[Laura center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness **LVF**

God of love, show us our place in this world
as channels of your love
for all the creatures of this earth -
for not one of us is forgotten in your sight.

Enlighten those who possess power and money
that they may avoid indifference,
that they may love the common good,
advance the weak,

and care for this world
in which we live.
The poor, the oppressed, and the earth
are crying out.

So we ask, Good and Gracious God, seize us with your power,
with your beautiful darkness, with your amazing light,
and help us to protect all life,
with all that we have and all that we are
as we work for your kin-dom
of justice, peace, love, and beauty.
-adapted from the Pope's Encyclical, 2015
Amen and Amen.

[All turn towards choir]

Introit Iona Alleluia TRADITIONAL CELTIC
Frank Hobbs, *Soloist,* Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor* From the Island of Iona

[Emily & Gavin to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer** **Emily & Gavin**

Gavin: Our Holy Scriptures tell us that we are all created in the image and likeness of God. In this place, we celebrate the Mystery of who God is. We remember that our tradition is rich in calling The Divine by many names: Amma, Abba, Loving Mother, Compassionate Father, Source of Life, Redeemer, Loving Presence, Holy One, Adonai.

Emily: Because of this Mystery, we invite you to pray The Lord's Prayer in your own tradition and language. In this way, we celebrate the interconnectedness of our lives, whether we come from near or from far. Let us now pray together as Jesus taught us…

Both: ***Our [God], who art in heaven,***
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace** **LVF**

As we share this ancient greeting,
we invite you to offer signs of peace to one another with a bow
- a gesture used broadly across many cultures
as a sign of greeting, respect, honor, humility, and love.
This morning, may it be an expression
of the intention of the peace with which we long to live
with one another, the world, and all creation.

For the gift of this new day
for waking again from the dreams of the night
for our bodies strengthened and our minds renewed
Thanks be to you, O God.

You are the stillness of the night,
you are the genesis of the morning
you are the dew of new creation.

Let there be peace in the human soul
let there be waking to new consciousness

In the life of the world this day
and in our hearts
let there be fresh hope for peace.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[Emily & Gavin to lectern]

Reading from Our Religious Tradition ***from the Gospel of John*** **Emily & Gavin**

Emily: Listen now to this reading from the Gospel of John, chapter 1…

Gavin: In the beginning, there was the Word;
the Word was in God's presence,

and the Word was God.
The Word was present to God
from the beginning.

Emily: Through the Word
all things came into being,
and apart from the Word
nothing came into being
that has come into being.
In the Word was life,
and that life was humanity's light—
–a Light that shines in the darkness,
a Light that the darkness has never overtaken.

Gavin: This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition Laura to center chancel]

Prayers with the People **LVF**

Invitation to Silence and Prayer
Each one of us knows things in the core of our being
that we have not necessarily been taught,
and some of this deep knowing may actually
be at odds with what our society or religion
has tried to teach us.

In this time, in this brave space we call home,
we are being invited to reawaken
to what we know in the depths of our being -
that the earth is sacred and that this sacredness
is at the heart of every human being and life-form.

As we are now in silence together,
let us breathe in this sacred space
knowing that God is with us
in this time and place. [jphilipnewell]

Silence

[Christoph plays transition out of silence]

Prayer of our Hearts
Creator Spirit,
we give thanks that your life-giving Presence

has been active in our universe for all the billions of years
that have passed since the first moments of its existence.

Working within and with what was there,
your Presence came to visible expression
in the formation of stars
and galaxies
and planets.

Rocks and grasses,
water and soil,
all living things, including us,
came to life with a conscious
awareness and appreciation
of your Presence.

Help us on this day
to marvel at this life,
as we continue to embrace
this Sacred Earth we call home.

Help us on this day
to celebrate the Source of all that is
and of all that shall be.
Amen and Amen!

[mmorwood/adapt]

[Christoph transition for Choir]

Meditation Anthem This Little Light of Mine
TRADITIONAL AFRICAN-AMERICAN SPIRITUAL
ARR. MOSES HOGAN
Lorenzo Zapata, *Soloist,* Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

[Christoph transition Michael to pulpit]

Sermon ***Reawakening to What Our Souls Already Know*** **ML**

[Christoph transition as Michael & Laura go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings **LVF & ML**

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

LVF: We are drawn together by the Wisdom of the universe,
nature's intelligence,
embodied in Jesus
and present in all souls

who gather at Wisdom's table.

We gather to receive grace to give up our foolish ways,
to walk in Wisdom's light,
to delight in creation and in one another,
as the Holy One delights in us.

ML: May we open the gates of our souls, that Wisdom may enter,
making us friends with God and one another.
We open in this time to the
transforming power of the Spirit.

LVF: You are welcome at this table if you have a little faith, a lot of faith, absolutely no faith, or are of another faith. This is the Table of the Christ, and the welcome is wide!

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup
At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[Emily to lectern when Communion is finished]

Invitation to Generosity **Emily**

Each morning brings us a newness
that we but need to step into.
It can wash us,
lift us,
heal us,
hold us
just as each of us has need.

As we give from our financial resources this morning,
to continue the work of this church
may we be open to the power that lies within us.
May we be full with a confidence in our strength.
May we move from empty routines
to the fullness of life
that we might live God's dream.

You will find information for online giving in your programs and appearing on your screens at home. Our Hospitality Team will also come forward now to receive your offerings. Thank you for your ongoing generosity through the resources, time, and talents you bring to strengthen our community to be the Love of the Divine in the world.

Offertory Art Thou Troubled? G. F. Handel
Tiffany Ho, *Soprano*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organ*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**
From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Gavin to lectern towards the end of the doxology]

***Prayer of Offering** **Gavin**
Holy One, as we give our offerings
may our eyes be open
to see you in all the colors of creation
as you use our generosity to awaken us
to a new sense of awe and wonder.

May we know you, O God, as the sacred presence that is real to us.
May we know you, O God, as the one who is the source of inspiration
and courage as you keep calling us forward
to share your dream for our world.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen.

Please be seated

[Michael and Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church **LVF & ML**
LVF: Insert events + Sanctuary on Wednesday this week

ML: Following week, Men's Group and Not Your Grandma's Bible Study meet

LVF: Sunday, Oct. 25, Annual Fall Festival following the service. Chili cookoff signups today at Coffee Hour in Mayflower.

Words of Blessing **ML**

May the God you see in all the colors of creation
awaken in you a sense of awe and wonder.
May the God who is a sacred presence be real to you.
May the God who is the source of inspiration and courage
keep calling you forward.
May your God go with you and bless you.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response Peace, Be Still Shawn Kirchner

Peace, be still, and know that I am God. Peace, be still, and know that I am
Peace, be still, and know. Peace, be still. Peace, be. Peace, peace, peace.

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Hymn for the Journey** ***Wake Now My Senses SLANE

Wake now my senses, and hear the Earth call,
feel the deep power of being in all,
keep with the web of creation your vow,
giving, receiving, as love shows us how.

Wake now my reason, reach out for the new,
join with each trav'ller who quests for the true,
honor the beauty and wisdom of time,
transcend our limits and touch the sublime.

Wake now my vision, the dream we hold dear,
brighten our pathway with radiance here,
journey together with all who will share,
love for the planet transformed by our care.

--lyrics Mikelson

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Short Prelude in D minor (Ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music – Dr. Ianthe Marini

When I stood on the rocks of Iona, Scotland, I felt a deep and immediate connection to my ancestors and the breath and matter that formed them. Though I am not of Indigenous Celtic descent, standing on rocks over 3 billion years old that had survived erosion, climate change,

billons of years of tectonic shifting, and that which stood through the forcible removal and genocide of the Indigenous people on those lands reawakened and reconnected me with a fully embodied knowledge of my own ancestry whose bodies experienced genocide in a different land. It is this *deep knowing* of which the Celts speak and it poured through my body without my even asking. Today, we begin Part II of our Fall Series, *Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul,* where we explore the Celtic theology of Original Goodness: a direct resistance of the dominant theology of the imperial church that insisted our nature at birth was corrupt and inherently sinful. Original Goodness tells us that which we already deeply know: that at our birth we are a reflection of the Divine themselves — a mirrored image of the soul of God.

To start this journey, we sing an *Alleluia* from this island which birthed Celtic theology. A melody that seems as though it has always been flowing, inviting us to sing it during our time, and after which it will keep flowing. When I was in Iona and our guide, the Celtic theologian John Phillip Newell, taught us this melody, a wave of excitement passed through me as I realized I had known the tune my entire life. I hadn't known of its ancient Celtic origins, but somehow, it had found its way into the life of a Mediterranean girl from Boston. And isn't music like that? It can remind us of our interconnectedness and wholeness, of the goodness that is innate within us, which connects us over time and place.

Tiffany sings and Christoph plays of this connection within and throughout us in Handel's melody, *Art Thou Troubled? Music will calm thee. Art thou weary? Rest shall be thine.* And Lorenzo and the Cathedral Choir also encourage our inner lights shining through Moses Hogan's arrangement of the well-loved African-American spiritual *This Little Light of Mine.* For in the theology of the Indigenous Celts we are reminded of that inner light—present at our birth—meant to be shared as a beacon for ourselves and others. In closing, we sing the Peace Canon of Los Angeles musician and friend Shawn Kirchner, where we sing individually and collectively, *Be Still and Know that I am Peace.*